died from a blood disease at the age of 56 in June 1916. Dr Sun was forced into exile in Japan, returning to China in 1917 when a republican form of government had been restored. By then the country had been plunged into even deeper chaos, with a weak central government and local warlords who were often little more than bandit-chieftains controlling their own fiefdoms in the provinces. Dr Sun tried in vain to reunify the fractured country. He died of liver cancer in March 1925 when he was only 58.

Lea, Dr Sun's American companion, who he wanted to make the chief of staff of the army of the Republic of China, had suffered a stroke in February 1912 and returned to the United States where he died in November. Dr Sun's revolutionary companions considered Lea an interloper, and strongly objected to the idea of having a foreigner as their army chief. Although China, as a country, was never colonized, European powers exerted their influence over the country from their colonial enclaves on the coast and that contributed to a deeply felt resentment of outsiders.

Hong Kong was British, the Portuguese were in Macau, and until the end of World War I the Germans had Qingdao. China was ruthlessly exploited by Western and Japanese commercial interests and the foreigners treated the Chinese as second-class citizens in their own country. It was hardly surprising that a Communist party was formed in 1921, and quickly gained support among urban intellectuals as well as from downtrodden peasants in the countryside.

Changes, albeit of a more peaceful nature, were also taking place in India in 1912. In June, the parliament in London promulgated the Government of India Act. Bengal, which had been divided in 1905 into a western part and the new province of Eastern Bengal and Assam, was reconstituted into three provinces—Bengal, corresponding to present-day West Bengal and Bangladesh, Bihar and Orissa, and Assam. Rather than being a centrally-ruled 'presidency' as before, reunited Bengal became a province under a governor. The creation of Assam as a separate province, which later got its own legislative assembly, meant that its borders had to be more clearly defined.

At that time, Assam included the present Indian states of Nagaland, Mizoram, Meghalaya, and Arunachal Pradesh. The two other northeastern Indian states of today, Tripura and Manipur, were princely states ruled by their own maharajas and never part of Assam. A centrally controlled Naga